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Satyanarayana Temple, Annavaram

Sri Veera Venkata Satyanarayana Swamy Temple is a Hindu-Vaishnavite temple located in Annavaram in Kakinada district of Andhra Pradesh, India.[1] Dedicated to Lord Satyanarayana Swamy, an incarnation of Lord Vishnu, the temple is situated on Ratnagiri Hill.[1] It is one of the most visited religious sites in Andhra Pradesh and is recognized as one of the state's wealthiest temples.[2] The temple holds significant importance as a major pilgrimage centre and is regarded by many as the second most prominent in the state after the Tirumala Venkateswara Temple.[3]

The temple attracts thousands of devotees daily, particularly for the Satyanarayana Vratham, a ritual performed for wealth, health, and prosperity. Consecrated in 1891, the temple has undergone various expansions and renovations, including significant reconstruction in the 1930s.[4]

Location

Annavaram is situated 18 km from Tuni, 51 km from Kakinada, 72 km from Rajahmundry, and 120 km from Visakhapatnam.[5] The temple is situated along National Highway 16 (NH16), which links Chennai and Kolkata. Annavaram is accessible through regular bus services provided by the Andhra Pradesh State Road Transport Corporation (APSRTC), with buses operating every 30 minutes from Kakinada,Rajahmundry and Tuni . The Annavaram railway station, located approximately 3 km from the temple, lies on the broad-gauge railway line between Vijayawada and Visakhapatnam. Most trains traveling on the route between Chennai and Kolkata include a stop at Annavaram.[6]

Sri Veera Venkata Satyanarayana Swamy Temple, Annavaram

శ్రీ వీర వెంకట సత్యనారాయణ స్వామి దేవాలయం, అన్నవరం

Gopuram of Satynarayana Temple, Annavaram

Religion	
Affiliation	Hinduism
District	Kakinada
Deity	Lord Veera Venkata Satyanarayana,
Governing body	Sri Veera Venkata Sathyanarayana Swamy Vari Devasthanam

Location	
Location	Annavaram
State	Andhra Pradesh
Country	India

Location in Andhra Pradesh

Coordinates	17°17′59.9″N 82°24′8.6″E

Architecture

Established	1891
Completed	1933–34

History

The temple's origins are linked to a vision experienced by a devout Brahmin named Eeranki Prakasa Rao (ఈరంకి ప్రకాశరావు), who lived in the village of Annavaram, located near Pithapuram. During the period of Raja Inuganti Venkata Ramarayanim Bahadur (రాజా ఇనుగంటి వేంకటరామరాయణిం బహదూర్), both Prakasa Rao and the local ruler had a simultaneous dream in which Lord Vishnu instructed them, "On the forthcoming Sravana Sukla Vidiya, under the Makha Nakshatra on a Thursday, I will manifest on the Ratnagiri Hill. You shall install my idol as per the sacred rituals and serve me."[4]

Following this divine revelation, Prakasa Rao and the ruler shared their visions with the villagers and prepared to visit Annavaram on Sravana Sukla Padyami of the Khara year. While searching for the deity on the hill, they discovered the idol, illuminated by sunlight beneath a Krishna Kutaja (Ankudu) tree. The villagers carefully uncovered the idol and transported it to the summit of Ratnagiri.[4]

On August 6, 1891 (Salivahana Saka 1813), the idol was consecrated following the traditional Vishnu Panchayatana system, alongside the installation of the Sri Matripada Vibhuti Maha Vaikuntha Narayana Yantra, which had been brought from Kasi. The original temple structure was a modest shed, which was later expanded into a more elaborate temple with contributions from devotees. The temple was reconstructed in stone during 1933–34 and showcases a unique blend of iconography.[4]

Legend

Annavaram is home to the sacred Ratnagiri Hill. According to the *Sthala Purana* (legend of the place), the renowned Meru mountain, one of the prominent mountains in Hindu mythology, performed severe penance to Lord Vishnu along with his wife Menaka. Pleased by their devotion, Vishnu blessed them with two sons, Bhadra and Ratnakara, who were born as mountains. Bhadra, after performing penance dedicated to Vishnu, was transformed into Bhadrachalam, the abode of Lord Rama. Similarly, Ratnakara's penance was rewarded when Vishnu appeared as Sri Veera Venkata Satyanarayana Swamy on the Ratnagiri Hill, also known as Ratnachalam.[4]

Architecture

Temple complex

View of the entire temple

The temple is located on Ratnagiri Hill, adjacent to the banks of the Pampa River. It can be reached by a 3-km road or through a stone pathway for pedestrians. Architecturally, the temple is designed to resemble a chariot, complete with four wheels at each corner, symbolizing the Jagannath concept of eternal movement through time.[6] The four wheels are meant to represent the Sun and the Moon. The main entrance of the temple has been adorned with gold plating, enhancing its grandeur.[1]

The structure follows the principles outlined in the *Agni Purana*, with the central sanctum symbolizing the Supreme Spirit. The ground floor features a distinct yantra, known as the Srimathripathvibhuti Vykuntha Maha Narayana Yantra, reputed for its special powers of attraction. This *yantra* is surrounded by deities forming a panchayatana, including Ganapati, Suryanarayanaswamy, Bala Tripurasundari, and Maheswaraswamy.[4]

The main sanctum houses an idol that is approximately 13 feet tall and cylindrical in shape, symbolizing the unity of the Trimurti with Brahma at the base, Siva in the center, and Vishnu at the top. The first floor holds the principal deity, Sri Veera Venkata Satyanarayana Swamy, accompanied by Goddess Anantha Lakshmi and Lord Siva.[7] Additionally, there is a nearby temple dedicated to Sri Rama, known as the kshetra palaka, which marks the site where the original idol was discovered. The temple also features a mandapam for conducting Satyanaraya Vrathams.[6]

Administration

The temple is being administered under Endowments department of Andhra Pradesh by a Trust board of 13 members.[8]

Significance

The temple attracts thousands of devotees daily, who visit to perform the Satyanarayana Vratham for various reasons, including wealth, health, and prosperity. Although Ekadasi is considered the most auspicious day for the ritual, it is performed by devotees on other days as well. The temple is a major pilgrimage site for both Vaishnavite and Shaivite devotees.[4] The shrine earned ₹26 crore revenue in 2007.[3]

Festivals

The temple observes several significant festivals throughout the year. Key celebrations include Telugu New Year's Day on Chaitra Suddha Padyami (March–April) and Sita Rama Kalyanam on Chaitra Suddha Navami (March–April). Sri Krishna Jayanti is celebrated on Sravana Bahula Ashtami (July–August), followed by the Lord's Jayanti on Sravana Suddha Vidiya (July–August). Ganapathi Navarathrulu is observed in Bhadrapadam (August–September), while Sarannavarathrulu takes place during Asviyujam (September–October). Other notable events include the Kanaka Durga Jatara on Vaisakha Suddha Panchami (April–May), Giripradakshinam on Karthika Suddha Purnima (October–November), and DeeJwalatoranam during Karthikam (October–November).[5]

Surrounding temples

In addition to the main temple, the Ratnagiri hill hosts other shrines, including:

- Sri Rama Temple: Located near the main temple, regarded as the original site of the idol's discovery.
- Vana Durga Temple: A highly revered shrine on Ratnagiri Hill, believed by locals to protect the temple premises at night.
- Kanaka Durga Temple: Also located on the hill, held in veneration alongside the Vana Durga Temple.
- Nerellamma Temple: The temple of the village deity located at the base of the hill.

Vana Durga temple on the hill

In popular culture

The temple has been depicted in various Telugu films over the years. Notable films featuring the temple include *Sankarabharanam* (1980), *Nuvve Nuvve* (2002), *Mr. & Mrs. Sailaja Krishnamurthy* (2004), and *Geetha Govindam* (2018).[9]

Gallery

Ratnagiri mountain range

Pushkarini at the temple

Annavaram hill view

Entrance arch on new Ghat road

Temple garden

Entrance arch inside the temple

Sunset view of the temple complex

View of the temple complex

View of the temple complex

Sundial inside the temple

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